

1. Close Reading of Borges' "The Library of Babel" based on partner discussion (Avery)

Reading Borges' *The Library of Babel* through a Sufi lens, we were interested in how both the story's theoretical construct and the practical events in it can be interpreted through a Sufi framework reflecting Sufi principles — specifically in terms of the Sufi "path" or "way." More broadly, one aspect of Sufism that we found relevant and interpretable in the text was that of the tension between intellectual/rationality, e.g. the rational pursuit of knowledge, vs. divine or intuitive knowledge. First, we interpreted the conceptual setup of the Library as being analogous to a Sufi mystical view of the world/humanity vis-à-vis the divine (God). While the chapter "Jewish, Christian, and Gnostic Themes" asserts that the Library is a "clear metaphor for the universe," we drew a connection between the library representing "the universe" (a more secular construct) and from a more Sufi angle, the capacity to interpret that specifically as God. We noted how Borges' description of the Library — as "total," "perfect, complete, and whole" — directly echoes the conception of the divine in Sufism. Thus, we noted that in both the world of the Library and in Sufism, there is a presupposition that total knowledge of the universe/God is available — it can theoretically be accessed — but that in both, the fundamental question arises of exactly how, both theologically and practically, a human can access it.

Thus examining pages 115-117 of *The Library*, we thought that the narrator's description of the different approaches of the groups of men in the Library, when faced with this (existential) challenge, can be read as reflecting Sufi principles. For instance, one of the main approaches — immediately seeking one's own "Vindication" — that falls through for the men in the story seemed to be a prime example of a misguided mentality from a Sufi lens with respect to the Sufi path, contradicting the Sufi principle of Repentance that calls one to accept and repent for one's sins instead of trying to absolve oneself of blame through (rational) justification. Similarly, we analyzed the next approach — the search to "eliminate all worthless books" in a "hygienic, ascetic rage" — through a Sufi lens. Here, the use of the word "ascetic," though perhaps harmless, is interesting given that in the Sufi tradition historically, asceticism (specifically "essential asceticism") was such a dominant mode of praxis on the path to mystical enlightenment. Nevertheless, there was always an understanding that Sufism was not practiced by simply *being* an ascetic, but rather that one practiced asceticism for the right reasons according to the Sufi principles: not to make others happy (a form of polytheism) and not even to be rewarded by God (countering true sincerity), but because one is earnest in one's goal to detach oneself from the world to devote oneself to the only true goal, union with God. Thus, perhaps the human impulse in Borges' story to solve the problem by doing something of an "ascetic" nature can be read analogously as acting on a misguided intention in Sufism. Finally, we similarly analyzed the approach of the other group of men in the story — to search "by [logical] regression" for the "idolized secret hexagon that sheltered Him [the Book Man]" — which also seems to fail as exemplifying that underlying notion in Sufism (as with other mystical traditions) aforementioned: the fundamental limitation, and even misguidedness, of attempting to unveil the Truth or Reality via the intellect, rationality or logic. (Instead, Sufism as well as Gnosticism emphasize the need for embodied experience in tandem with/giving rise to intuitive knowledge in order to unveil, and then become close to or ultimately one with, the divine.) Borges even goes on to write that "Infidels claim that the rule in the Library is not 'sense,' but 'non-sense,' and that 'rationality' (even humble, pure coherence) is an almost miraculous exception." Although

interestingly, the narrator goes on to decisively condemn this viewpoint — claiming it to be proof of “the infidels’...desperate ignorance” — the mere raising of this philosophical point foregrounds this dichotomous, paradoxical tension between order and disorder, between intellectual and intuitive knowledge.

2. Short commentary on which aspects of "world literature" or "literatures of the world" Borges' engagement with Sufism reflects or embodies (Aynura)

From Ottmar Ette’s “Literatures of the World,” “world literature” can be thought of as rooted in multilingualism and a critical distance from nationalism. By engaging the reader in deep philosophical questions of the universe and the ego instead of it being limited to one nationalistic idea or way of thought, we can say that Borges’ stories achieve this. In other words, we can say that his stories transcend national as well as temporal borders, thus lending them a universal and timeless quality. This aspect is perhaps helped by the “supernatural,” mystical aura of his stories, as though they exist in a realm above the mundane or real: for instance, *The Library* alongside *The Zahir* and *The Aleph* almost read as sci-fi in their speculative natures, albeit one that is metaphorical or allegorical and philosophical. This aspect is perhaps also helped by the fact that as one of the background texts emphasized, Borges often eschewed deep character development and perhaps by extension, very specific narrative situating.

At the same time, Borges deeply engages specifically with Islamic philosophical concepts with which he was familiar — namely the Sufi concepts of *Zahir* (the apparent, embodied by a coin) and *Batin* (the hidden). As an Argentine writer, he richly incorporates and works with Islamic thought where he excels in translation, which qualifies him for what Ette calls for in “literatures of the world.” Borges' stories can thus challenge David Damrosch's concern that “world literature” risks harmful or reductive decontextualization. Borges' way of invoking Sufi thought is that he compels the aware reader to think *with* Islam as opposed to authoritatively representing it. Thus, he is arguably neither an anthropologist nor mere translator, but rather a writer-philosopher inspired by concepts from different national and temporal traditions.

Borges also does not engage with Sufism at a surface level, but rather incorporates core concepts as discussed above into his narratives. In this process, we could say that the historical/mystical Sufi concepts perhaps inevitably become 'transformed' in the context of his stories: a celebrated outcome of “literatures of the world” according to Ette. In the case of *The Zahir*, the coin is both an object of material obsession and a symbol of remembrance and spiritual connection. That said, it lends itself to different philosophical interpretations and meanings: it is a bridge to both philosophical/psychological questions of the secular notion of “madness” as well as to Sufi practices of devotion and its theological underpinnings. As we read in Rumi’s *The Sick Slave Girl*, attachment to external material goods as well as (human) love lead to sickness and detachment from the higher truth (God), which directly parallels the events in *The Zahir*. This idea thus reinforces the notion that in order to reach a higher truth or reality, one should engage with spiritual connection and let go of pure rationality, as love towards and for God often transcends the rational. Yet at the same time, as we have seen and practiced before, it is also entirely possible to read *The Zahir* through a non-Sufi lens. Therefore, the coin as a symbol both embodies and is in dialogue with multiple traditions at once: the secular and mystical, and

different traditions therein (e.g. psychology and Sufism). We can therefore say that Borges' stories embody the concept of "literatures of the world" in part due to this multiplicity, this merging — and making something new of — different cultural (and temporal) traditions.